

A SELF-GUIDED 30-DAY PROGRAMME

CHEMSEX RECOVERY

A practical programme for taking back control

Stop or move toward abstinence • Understand triggers • Manage cravings
Prepare for weekends, loneliness and sober intimacy

Work at your own pace. Start with safety.



Important safety information

This programme is educational. It does not replace medical care, addiction treatment or emergency support.

- GHB/GBL dependence can make sudden stopping dangerous.
- Severe withdrawal can include confusion, hallucinations or seizures.
- If you may be dependent, speak to a medical professional before stopping.
- In an emergency or severe withdrawal, seek urgent care now.



Recovery is more than abstinence

The goal is a life where chemsex no longer controls your choices.

- Manage cravings and emotions

- Explore sober sex and intimacy

- Reduce loneliness; repair relationships

- Restore sleep, routine and meaningful activity

- Notice warning signs early

- Learn from setbacks and begin again



Decide your goal

Readiness does not need to be exaggerated. Choose the truest answer today.

☐ **Stop chemsex**

☐ **Stop drugs during sex**

☐ **Stop a particular drug**

☐ **Reduce my use**

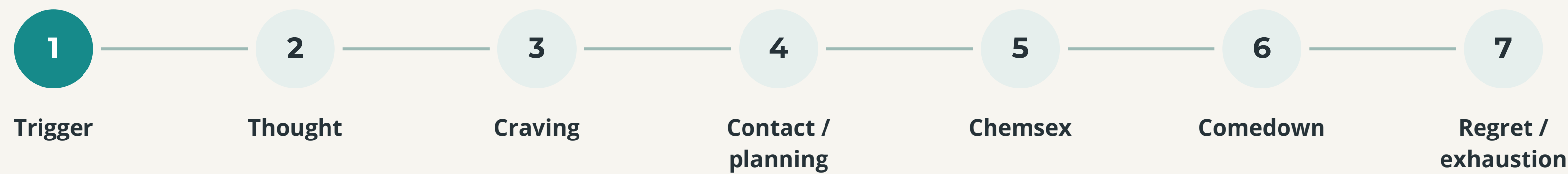
☐ **I'm unsure**

My goal:



The chemsex cycle

Interrupt the cycle before the session begins — earlier is usually easier.





Find your triggers

Triggers can be external, internal or both.

- PEOPLE — partners, contacts, dealers

- PLACES — homes, clubs, hotels

- APPS — dating, messaging, groups

- EMOTIONS — lonely, stressed, rejected

- SEXUAL — fantasies, porn, arousal

- TIME — weekends, late nights, payday



Your trigger map

Complete this honestly. Awareness creates choice.

People	Places	Apps
Emotions	Times	Sexual situations



Find the real need

“I want sex” may be the surface thought. What might be underneath?

- Connection

- Validation

- Excitement

- Confidence

- Escape

- Relief from loneliness or stress

What am I actually looking for?



Your personal pattern

Take a moment. Short, honest answers are enough.

When I am feeling...

I usually think...

Then I usually...

This leads to...

Afterwards I usually feel...

Where can I interrupt the pattern?



Don't rely only on willpower

Make the healthy choice easier before cravings arrive.

- ☐ Remove drugs and equipment

- ☐ Delete or block contacts

- ☐ Leave high-risk groups

- ☐ Remove apps temporarily

- ☐ Avoid high-risk locations

- ☐ Tell a trusted person

- ☐ Arrange professional support



Your first 72 hours

Plan concrete basics for the earliest recovery days.

Food

Sleep

Support

Distraction

Safe environment



Change your environment

Recovery is not a willpower test. It is changing the conditions around your choices.

- Avoid places linked to sessions

- Create distance from high-risk people

- Remove easy access to apps

- Spend vulnerable hours somewhere safer



The phone problem

Your phone can turn a passing urge into a plan in seconds.

- Delete apps

- Block contacts

- Leave groups

- Mute notifications

- Remove saved photos and messages

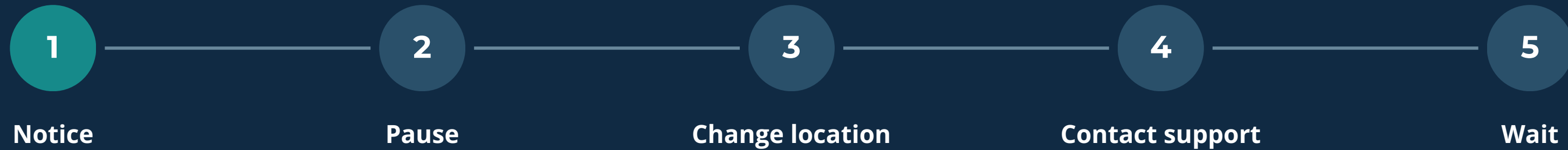
- Put the phone away during high-risk hours

ONE ACTION I WILL TAKE NOW: _____



A craving is not an order

The aim is to prevent automatic action — not to make every feeling disappear.





The 30-minute craving plan

Create distance between urge and action.





I WANT TO USE

I can wait 30 minutes. I do not need to decide now.

CONTACTS NOT TO CONTACT _____

SUPPORT PERSON _____

SAFE PLACE _____

ACTION _____

MY REASON FOR STOPPING _____



Urge surfing

Slow your breathing. Observe the urge as a wave that rises, peaks and passes — without acting.

Where do I feel it in my body?

What thoughts appear?

What happens if I wait?



“Just one more session”

Remember the whole pattern. Do not negotiate with a craving.

What happened last time?

Where did one session lead?

What do I want tomorrow morning?



Plan Friday before Friday

Do not leave high-risk hours empty.

● ☐ Decide where I'll be

● ☐ Choose safe people

● ☐ Plan dinner

● ☐ Book an activity

● ☐ Add movement or exercise

● ☐ Arrange social contact

● ☐ Remove access

● ☐ Tell my support person



Your weekend plan

Predictable does not mean boring. It means fewer openings for the cycle.

FRIDAY 18:00	FRIDAY 20:00	FRIDAY 22:00
SATURDAY morning	SATURDAY afternoon	SATURDAY evening
SUNDAY morning	SUNDAY afternoon	SUNDAY evening



Dealing with loneliness

Chemsex can offer company, attention, sexual contact, excitement and belonging. Recovery may feel empty at first — build connection deliberately.

- MESSAGE TODAY — who?

- CALL TODAY — who?

- MEET TODAY — who and where?



Sober sex may feel different

Your brain may have learned “sex = drugs”. Without drugs, sex can initially feel less intense, awkward or unfamiliar.

- This is relearning — not failure.
- Go slowly and stay curious.
- Pleasure and confidence can return with time.
- Consent, comfort and connection matter more than performance.



Take the pressure off

Intimacy can be rebuilt gradually.

- Touch

- Kissing

- Conversation

- Dating

- Masturbation

- Affection

- Sensual experiences

- Rest and closeness

NEW RULE: SEX DOESN'T HAVE TO BE EXTREME TO BE GOOD.



What do you actually want?

You are building something new — not only giving something up.

When I use drugs during sex, I feel...

What I actually want to feel is...

I want sex to give me...

I want relationships to give me...



Replace the reward

Match the alternative to the need.

- EXCITEMENT — exercise, travel, hobbies

- PLEASURE — food, music, nature, sex

- RELAXATION — sleep, walks, films

- CONNECTION — friends, groups, community

- ACHIEVEMENT — work, learning, projects



Your replacement list

Keep this list visible — especially before high-risk times.

When I want **EXCITEMENT**, I will...

When I want **CONNECTION**, I will...

When I want **SEXUAL CONNECTION**, I will...

When I want **STRESS RELIEF**, I will...

When I need **SOMETHING TO DO**, I will...



Rebuild your daily routine

Recovery becomes easier when days stop revolving around drugs.





Sleep & physical recovery

Your body may need time. Keep the basics steady.

- Regular sleep and wake times
- Daylight early in the day
- Regular food and hydration
- Gentle movement
- Quiet bedtime routine
- Do not use drugs for sleep without medical advice
- Seek healthcare advice for severe or persistent problems



Don't do everything alone

"I'm trying to stop chemsex and may need support when I have cravings."

Choose one safe person. Ask if you can contact them — and whether they can help you stay away from sessions.

One supportive person can make a real difference.



Professional & peer support

Different kinds of support can work together.

- Addiction specialists and drug/alcohol services

- Sexual-health clinics and HIV services

- Therapists and LGBTQ+ organisations

- Peer groups and recovery communities

- Controlling Chemsex — 1:1 support and peer mentoring
controllingchemsex.com

- Global Chemsex Toolbox
globalchemsextoolbox.com



More chemsex & LGBTQ+ support

Specialist services understand the link between sex, identity and drug use.

- **ANTIDOTE — LONDON FRIEND**
1:1 support, relapse prevention, groups and sober socials
londonfriend.org.uk/antidote
- **LGBT FOUNDATION**
Chemsex support, recovery programmes and peer groups including ChemSafe
lgbt.foundation/help/chemsex-support
- **CURRENT REACH**
Some programmes support LGBTQ+ people in Greater Manchester and Liverpool; check current eligibility online.



Online & international support

Use directories to find help that fits your location and needs.

- CHEMSEX CARE FINDER
Counsellors, groups, buddy support and treatment
chemsexcare.com

- LGBT HERO CHEMSEX SUPPORT HUB
lgbthero.org.uk/chemsex

- LGBT HERO SUPPORT DIRECTORY
lgbthero.org.uk/find-help



Find local support

Try LGBTQ+ organisations, sexual-health clinics, drug/alcohol services and peer groups.

“My drug use is connected to sex and I want help stopping.”

Ask for help before a crisis. You do not need to explain everything in the first conversation.



Save your support contacts

Keep this somewhere accessible. Do not wait for a crisis to search.

Organisation

Website

Phone / email

Person

Their phone



Sexual health

Recovery includes looking after your whole health — without shame.

- Arrange HIV, STI and hepatitis testing
- Check recommended vaccinations
- Discuss PrEP if it may be useful
- Ask about PEP after a recent possible HIV exposure
- PEP is time-sensitive — usually it needs to start within 72 hours
- Seek urgent local medical or sexual-health advice



GHB/GBL: a special warning

Frequent or prolonged use can make stopping suddenly unsafe.

- Withdrawal can include severe anxiety

- Confusion or agitation

- Hallucinations

- Seizures

- Contact a medical professional before stopping

- Seek emergency care for severe withdrawal or any medical emergency



Know your warning signs

Spotting the pattern early gives you more options.

- Thinking about chemsex constantly

- Reinstalling apps

- Contacting old partners

- Staying awake late

- Isolating or feeling overwhelmed

- Romanticising sessions

- Telling yourself “just once”

- Planning drug sources

MY BIGGEST WARNING SIGN: _____



If you have a lapse

A lapse is information, not the end of recovery.





Days 1–30: your recovery plan

One phase at a time.

- DAYS 1–3 — STABILISE

Safety and medical advice • remove access • eat and sleep • support • avoid triggers

- DAYS 4–7 — BREAK THE PATTERN

Map triggers • block access • make a craving card • plan the weekend • contact services • sexual-health care

- DAYS 8–30 — BUILD

Weekly connection • movement • sleep • drug-free activities • support • sober intimacy • review triggers

My next 30 days

MY GOAL _____ BIGGEST TRIGGER _____

BIGGEST WARNING SIGN _____ MY CRAVING RESPONSE _____

PERSON TO CONTACT _____ PROFESSIONAL / SERVICE _____

WHAT I'M BUILDING INSTEAD _____

**You don't have to change your entire life today.
You only have to make the next healthy decision.**

Pause • Ask for help • Change your environment • Ride out the craving • Start again when necessary

RECOVERY IS POSSIBLE